

A

Ways of expressing yourself

example	meaning
The message from doctors and researchers has come through loud and clear : smoking harms your health.	clearly and very definitely
You mustn't be afraid to speak your mind ; it's important that everyone hears your views.	state your opinion very clearly and openly
She told me the bad news in a very matter-of-fact way.	without any feeling or emotion

B

Problems with communication

In these conversations, the second person repeats or sums up what the first person says using an idiom.

Sam: I told Henry a dozen times not to use that computer, but he still keeps asking if he can.

Beth: Yes, he just **won't take no for an answer**.

Anna: Toby just never stops! You try to tell him something and he goes on talking while you're talking.

Olivia: I know, it's impossible to **get a word in edgewise**.

Rita: I was trying to tell Liam that I know who stole the key, but he just kept talking about how expensive new locks are, which is a different question altogether.

Steve: I know. It's completely **beside the point**.

Gina: I think Emma completely misunderstood the main thing we were trying to say.

Jo: Yes, she completely **missed the point**.

C

Other useful idioms connected with communication

Don't ask Nathan to relax. He **doesn't know the meaning of the word**. [it is pointless to talk to him about relaxing; it's not in his character to do so]

She repeated what the doctor said **word for word**. [using the exact words the doctor had used]

If I were you, I'd read **the small/fine print** before you use your new credit card. [the rules, restrictions and conditions, which are often written in very small letters]

To ask me to look after her three children for a week is rather **a tall order**, don't you think? [a task, request or favour which is not reasonable / too big to ask someone to do]

Whether she is cleverer than her brother is **a matter of opinion**. [something different people will have different opinions about – it usually means you don't agree with the idea]

There's **a question mark (hanging) over** the future of the tennis club. [nobody knows if it will continue to exist or not]

English is **a lingua franca** in a lot of countries nowadays. [/'lɪŋgwə 'fræŋkə/ a language used for day-to-day public communication, which is not the speakers' own language]

28.1 Match each idiom on the left with the situation in which it could be used on the right. A

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|-------------------------------|--------------------------|---|
| 1 get a word in edgeways | ☐ | a She keeps on asking, even though we said no. |
| 2 miss the point | ☐ | b She told me exactly what her friend said. |
| 3 speak your mind | ☐ | c It's impossible to interrupt her, she talks non-stop. |
| 4 won't take no for an answer | ☐ | d She didn't really understand what I wanted to say. |
| 5 (repeat) word for word | ☐ | e He doesn't hide his personal opinions at all. |

28.2 Use the idioms from exercise 28.1 to rewrite these sentences.

- Sofia will never just accept a refusal.
- Joss always states his opinions quite openly.
- Sara never seems to understand what we're trying to say to her.
- She told us everything the teacher said to her in every detail.
- I tried to tell her, but it was impossible to interrupt her.

28.3 Answer these questions.

- There's a question mark hanging over the whole wildlife area project.
In your own words, what's the problem?
- It's no good asking her to help. She doesn't know the meaning of the word.
Does she usually help people? Explain.
- If you read the small print, you'll see you can't get your money back.
Where do we usually find *small print*? What is another way of saying this idiom?
- Tom: Miranda's a brilliant musician.
Amy: That's a matter of opinion.
Does Amy think Miranda's a brilliant musician? Explain.
- English is a lingua franca in several Asian countries.
Is English the official language in these countries? Explain.

28.4 Complete each of these idioms.

- The government's message to the voters is and clear: vote for us and we'll reduce taxes.
- I think it's rather a to ask students to write a 500-word composition in one hour. It would take at least two hours.
- That has nothing to do with what we are talking about; it's completely the point.
- He has a very way of telling you things: no emotion or feelings whatsoever.

Over to you

Try to collect more idioms connected with speaking, writing and communicating in general. Look up keywords connected with these topics in a good general dictionary or in an idiom dictionary and see what idioms you find, for example, words like *talk*, *speak*, *hear*, *word*, etc.